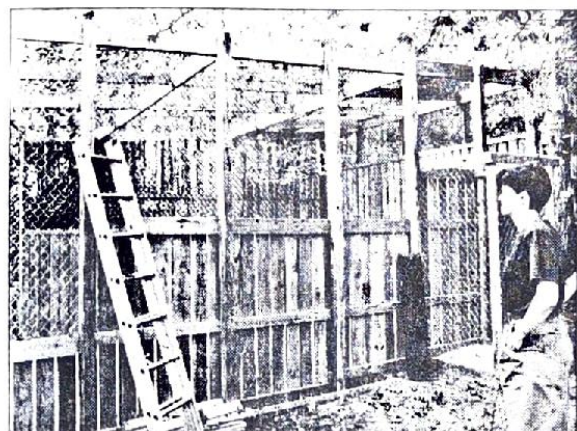




Photos by TOM FRANKLIN/Staff

Something new every visit: A red-tailed hawk (top) sits in its new cage at the Carolina Raptor Center; it's one of four new cages built in the last year. Laura Keistler (bottom), development officer at the Raptor Center, says, "People can come back every few months and see something new," like the soon-to-be-completed osprey cage she's looking at.

Researchers' gathering a feather in center's cap

Raptor foundation convention in Charlotte

By PAT BORDEN GUBBINS
Staff Writer

The Carolina Raptor Center is about to host a major convention, with up to 600 people expected to gather Nov. 3-7 at the Marriott City Center in Charlotte.

The Raptor Research Foundation Convention will attract people from all over the United States and several foreign countries, said Laura Keistler, development officer at the Raptor Center.

The convention is a significant coup for the center, located on 57 acres at Latta Plantation Park in north Mecklenburg County.

"We're really excited," Keistler said. "It will bring a lot of people to Charlotte, as well as get a lot of attention for the Raptor Center nationally."

During the convention, wildlife artists and vendors will have exhibits of fine art, jewelry, T-shirts and books to benefit the Raptor Research Foundation.

A symposium Nov. 6 will be led by David M. Bird of the Avian Science and Conservation Center at McGill University in Montreal.

All convention events will take place uptown, but tours of the Raptor Center will be included as an option.

The center takes in injured birds of prey to treat and release, if possible. Those with permanent damage are used for educational programs.

Visitors to the Raptor Center these days will see a number of improvements, said Executive Director Pat Marcum.

"We have built four new cages in the past year," she said. "People can come back every few months and see something new."

The newest addition is an aviary designed for ospreys. Before long, visitors will be able to see the birds in a setting that includes a pond, dock and pilings, Marcum said.

"We're having to experiment how to do this so it will work well. Ospreys are fish hawks, and we think they deserve a water supply in their cage," Marcum said.

The next major project is to build an aviary to house 10 bald eagles, which Marcum hopes to complete by the end of next summer. "It will be 130 feet long, 80 feet deep and 40 feet high," she said.

"Our plans are to work with the U.S. Army Corps of Engineers to do the planning and draw the blueprints. They're going to help us make a presentation to one of the large corporations to fund the project."

The private agency receives no tax money and depends on grants, large donations and fund-raisers for its improvements, although it has charged admission fees since July 1992.

And that has helped some.

"It used to be where we had salary money for two or three weeks in advance," said Marcum. "Now we have it for a month in advance. I would like to get to the place where we have it for six months in advance."

"Most places would consider that being in dire straits, but now we are able to relax a little bit, pay the electricity bills and feed the birds. If you've never had much, having a little bit sounds like a lot."

The Raptor Center attracts about 20,000 visitors a year, which brings in \$2,000 to \$3,000 a month, she said. But expenses run about \$12,000 a month, and donations still pay most of the bills.

The center currently has between 75 and 80 nonreleasable birds that it uses in its education program. Another 40 to 50 birds are being rehabilitated.

"This is our lowest time of the year, late summer and early fall, when there is still plenty of food (in the wild) and not much stress on them," said Marcum. "We have released all the babies. This is our rest period right now in rehab. In November and December, it starts building up again."

For 10 years, volunteers worked out of two mobile units that served as office and hospital on the site. The new environmental center, which opened in May 1992, now provides office, classroom and exhibit space.

The next major improvement will be a proper rehabilitation hospital for the birds, said Keistler.

"Right now, we are in the preliminary stages," she said. "We will probably start the planning process the beginning of 1994."

Have a hoot for Halloween

The Carolina Raptor Center staff is inviting kids to put on their costumes and spend this Halloween with them learning about owls and vultures.

On Saturday and Sunday, programs at the Raptor Center will dispel the myths surrounding the "scary" reputations of those birds.

"Owls! Owls! Fantastical Fowls!" will be presented in the center's amphitheater at 1 and 2:30 p.m. Saturday. The program will focus on the folklore and myths surrounding these wide-eyed raptors of the night.

"Weathering area" programs at 11:30 a.m., 12:30 p.m., 2 p.m. and 3 p.m. both days will feature close-up viewing and photographic opportunities of several species of North American raptors. For the Halloween weekend, Raptor Center volunteers will spotlight the benefits of vultures and owls.

Admission to the Carolina Raptor Center is \$2 for adults, \$1 for students and senior citizens and free for children younger than 6. All children dressed as eagles, owls, hawks, falcons or vultures will be admitted free.

The center is in Latta Plantation Park, off Beatties Ford Road, about 12 miles north of uptown Charlotte. For more information, call the center at 875-6521 weekdays 9 a.m.-5 p.m.

Want to go?

The Raptor Research Foundation Convention is open to the public. The fee for nonfoundation members is \$80. For details, call Laura Keistler at the Carolina Raptor Center, 875-6521, weekdays 9 a.m.-5 p.m. The Carolina Raptor Center, on Sample Road off Beatties Ford Road about 12 miles north of uptown, is open 10 a.m.-5 p.m. Tuesday through Sunday. Admission is \$2 for adults, \$1 for senior citizens and children 6 and older, and free for children younger than 6.